Payday Tides

Game concept and design document | 16 October 2026

The idea. A month can add up on paper and still fail on Tuesday. Payday Tides makes cash-flow timing a short, replayable puzzle. Players move necessary payments only within the dates a fictional provider allows, make one consequential choice, then run a 14-day calendar. A daily balance chart and transaction ledger show the first shortfall, so the player can revise the plan rather than guess.

The playable prototype

Four self-contained browser stories are live at seb-and.itch.io/payday-tides. Each has a failing default and at least one fully funded route. The game runs without an account, bank connection, analytics, or personal financial data. It works with mouse, keyboard, and touch; sound is optional. Progress stays in the browser. Typical play time is 5-10 minutes.

What players learn by doing

1. The three-day gap. A planned bulk food shop can move within an agreed window. Moving it after the next weekend shift covers the bill without debt or skipping meals.

2. The quiet renewal. A valued subscription, a pharmacy bill, and two paydays expose the difference between canceling a service and changing payment timing.

3. Two possible Fridays. A shorter workweek shrinks the buffer. Players compare both income outcomes before deciding whether a date move, extra shift, or advance is worthwhile.

4. The call before the fee. A provider-confirmed childcare extension and a short loan both bridge a gap, but the loan buys a larger immediate buffer at a later fee. The game explains that real providers can refuse or charge.

Core loop and learning evidence

Select legal payment days and one move; run the calendar; inspect the first shortfall, chart, and ledger; revise. A story-specific optional question checks the lesson after a successful plan and explains wrong answers. Three stars reward a funded plan with at least a $10 low-point buffer and no borrowing fee or stated personal sacrifice. The score is a game rule, not personal financial advice.

Current validation and limits

The legal date/move space is exhaustively tested in the source, and the hosted build was exercised on desktop and a 390px mobile viewport. An independent reviewer played the exact hosted build and found it a credible cash-category entry. The first three stories still use a similar date-change loop; no independent classroom or retention study has been run. A future pilot would test whether new players can identify the first shortfall and explain timing versus borrowing.

Rights, AI, and award route

Original code, copy, shapes, and sound cues were made for this entry. OpenAI Codex assisted design, implementation, testing, and writing; AI use is disclosed on itch and in the jam form. Sebastien Andersson retains the game IP subject to Zoud's published non-exclusive promotional license for the submitted version. This entry seeks a judged cash category prize, not development funding or a milestone agreement. No award is guaranteed.